

Identifying when a pronoun can be omitted

Sometimes a relative pronoun can be omitted from a relative clause without affecting the sense of a sentence. This only works if the pronoun is the object of the clause—the person or thing receiving the action.

Joe had to clean up the mess **that** the toad had made. ✓

restrictive relative clause

that the toad had made

This is the object of the relative clause, so it can be omitted without changing the meaning of the sentence.

subject

Joe had to clean up the mess **the toad had made**. ✓

The sentence makes sense without the relative pronoun and object *that*.

• Although **whom** is grammatically correct, **who** is almost always used instead in **everyday** English.

GLOSSARY

Clause A grammatical unit that contains a subject and a verb. Sentences are made up of one or more clauses.

Object The person or thing that is receiving the action of the verb.

Relative pronoun A pronoun that links one part of a sentence to another by introducing a relative clause, which describes an earlier noun or pronoun.

Subject The person or thing that is performing the action of the verb.

Which or that?

Historically *which* and *that* were interchangeable, and could be used for either type of relative clause. It is now usual practice to use *that* for restrictive clauses (see below) and *which* for nonrestrictive clauses. This helps to differentiate one type of information from the other.

The principal felt calm, **which** was unusual.

This is a nonrestrictive relative clause, because it gives extra—but not essential—information about the principal.

Joe held the toad **that** had escaped.

This is a restrictive relative clause, because it helps to identify which toad is being described.

calm, **which** was unusual. He eyed
held the toad **that** had escaped.

Restrictive relative clauses

Restrictive relative clauses are sometimes called “defining” or “essential” clauses, because they identify who or what is being referred to and are therefore vital to the meaning of a sentence. Restrictive clauses are not separated from the rest of a sentence by commas.

Joe held the toad
that had escaped.

This relative pronoun is acting as the subject of the relative clause—the thing that did the escaping.

This is a restrictive relative clause—it identifies which toad had escaped.